

Data-Driven Decision-Making Capacity of State VR Agencies

Highlights



Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) agencies report confidence in the data they collect.



VR agencies lack the statistical capacity to perform robust data analyses or estimate their own models.



Agencies have the ability to contract with external partners for data-related needs.

Introduction

The Evidence-Based Policy-Making Act of 2018 requires Federal agencies to use their data to develop statistical evidence to support policy and programmatic decisions. One such tool to make these programmatic decisions is a Return on Investment (ROI) model.

ROI modeling requires expertise in three key areas:

1. Data Management



to clean and link data from different sources.

2. Data Visualization



to describe patterns in the data.

3. Statistical Analysis



to accurately program and estimate the model with statistical software.

Methods

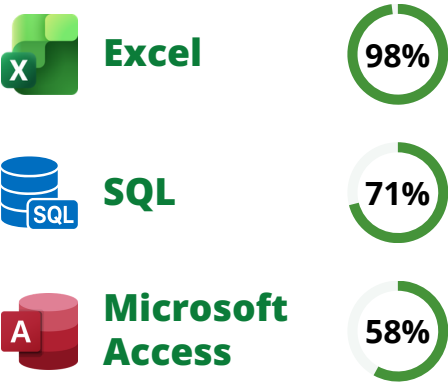
To assess VR agency capacity to calculate ROI, we surveyed state/Federal VR agency administrators (n = 45, 64%) and asked for details about the availability of relevant software programs and staff expertise to use those programs to conduct Data Management, Data Visualization, and Statistical Analysis actions. The results are on the next page.



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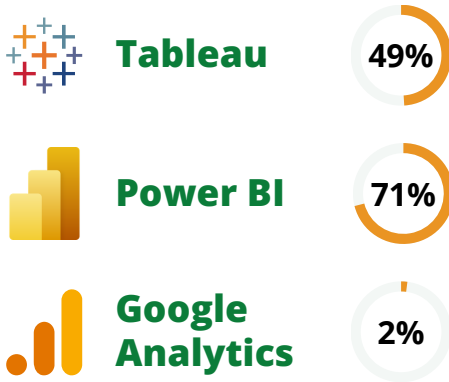
Data Management

Agencies had **strong** staff and software capacity in:



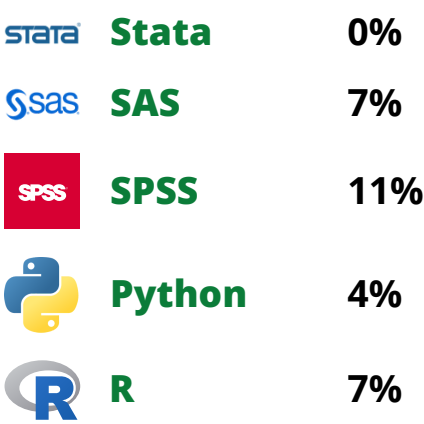
Data Visualization

Agencies had **moderate** staff and software capacity in:



Statistical Analysis

Agencies had **poor** staff and software capacity in:



Discussion

Results point to capacity gaps that would significantly hinder most agencies’ application of even a simplified ROI model. Based on these findings, we suggest the following recommendations to build VR decision-making capacity:

71% of respondents lacked internal statistical capacity to analyze data with any of the listed programs.



Invest in technical assistance and training focused on program evaluation and quality assurance.



Create education pathways within counselor training programs that integrate data management and statistical skills.



Establish consultant and research partnerships to fill immediate capacity gaps.



Promote cross-agency collaboration at the state level to share data expertise (e.g., utilizing economists, epidemiologists).



Conclusion

The Evidence-Based Policy-Making Act of 2018 calls on federal agencies to use government data and rigorous data analysis techniques as a routine part of policy making. To meet this goal, government agencies need to build internal and external data management, visualization, and statistical capacities.

For the VR program, our study indicates that additional infrastructure is needed and will require the support and commitment of RSA, individual VR agencies, and the research community.